

CORE FORMULA

Full sequence: Describe -> Express -> Assert -> Reinforce, then stay Mindful, Appear confident, Negotiate. -> **Minimum viable move:** facts -> impact -> ask or no -> why it helps. -> **Four-sentence form:** “When X happened, Y was the effect. I need Z. That would help because A. I can flex on B, but the main ask is Z.” -> **Boundary form:** “When X happens, it creates Y. I can't do Z. What I can do is A. If that doesn't work, we need another plan.” -> **Field rule:** be precise about the request and flexible about the route.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Here's what happened, here's how it affects me, here's what I need, and here's why it helps. I can flex on the details, not on the core ask.

BEST FOR

- Asking for a specific change in behaviour.
- Saying no to a request without over-explaining.
- Renegotiating workload, timing, boundaries or recurring friction.
- Raising a concern when you're tempted to hint, resent, withdraw or over-escalate.
- Preparing for a conversation where you tend to lose the point under pressure.
- Turning a vague grievance into an actionable request.

PHRASE BANK

One-breath starters · Quick openers

- "Here's what happened, and here's what I need."
- "The main ask is this — I can flex on the rest."
- "Can we settle this one thing before we leave the meeting?"
- "Short version: I need it by noon tomorrow."
- "I can't do the whole thing, but I can do part of it."
- "I'd like to sort one thing before we move on."

Describe — facts without blame · Naming the facts

- "The last two meetings started about fifteen minutes late."
- "The agreement was that I'd handle the slides and you'd send the figures."
- "I got the change request after the final version had already gone out."
- "You asked me to cover Saturday with one day's notice."
- "The figures came in Thursday afternoon; the deadline was Friday morning."

Express — own the impact · Owning the effect

- "That leaves me rushed and more likely to miss something."
- "I felt put on the spot."
- "I'm concerned the current setup isn't sustainable."
- "I want to help, but I'm already at capacity."
- "That gave me very little time to review it properly."

Assert — the ask or the no · Direct request / refusal

- "Please send the figures by 2 pm today."
- "I'm not available for Saturday."
- "I need us to agree the handoff before we leave this meeting."

- "Please raise changes before final approval, not after."
- "I can discuss options, but I can't take on the whole task."
- "This is the boundary I can keep."
- "I need the draft by noon the day before submission."

Reinforce — why it helps · The constructive reason

- "That gives me enough time to do the work properly."
- "That keeps the workload predictable for both of us."
- "That helps us avoid a rushed correction later."
- "That makes it easier for me to say yes when I actually can help."
- "That gives us both time to catch problems before the client sees it."

Mindful — stay with the point · Returning under deflection

- "I hear there are other issues. I'm happy to discuss those after this — right now I need to settle the deadline."
- "I'm not debating intent. I'm asking for the handoff to happen by 2 pm."
- "We can come back to the wider history. The decision in front of us is the timing."
- "We can discuss that separately. Right now I'm talking about this one thing."
- "I'm staying with the request: the draft by noon."
- "I understand you're disappointed. I'm still not available."
- "That's a fair point, and I still need an answer on the deadline."

Negotiate — flexible detail, stable core · Workable alternatives

- "I can't do Saturday, but I can help find someone else today."
- "I need the draft by noon; if it's not all ready, send the sections that are done."
- "I can't say yes to that scope, but I can do a smaller version by Friday."
- "What option would meet your need without putting this back on me?"
- "Core figures by noon works; the appendix by 4 pm is fine if you flag what's unfinished."
- "I can review one section by 4 pm, or help find who else has capacity."
- "Let me put this in writing: here's what happened, here's the effect, and here's what I need by when — if that timing doesn't work, propose an alternative first."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: I guess I'll just do it again. (a hint wrapped in resentment — the ask never lands)
Better: Please send it earlier next time. (clearer, but vague on timing and reason)
Best: The last two sets came in under a day before deadline, which leaves me rushing. I need them by noon the day before — that cuts the error risk. If the appendix is late, send the core figures first.
- Weak: You clearly don't care about my time. (blame-first — the facts get buried)
Better: I can't cover Saturday because I have a prior commitment. (direct boundary, brief reason)
Best: You asked me to cover Saturday with a day's notice. I'm already committed and it puts me in a bind. I can't take this Saturday. If requests come earlier I can usually help — and I can help you message the group today.
- Weak: It's fine, don't worry about it. (withdraws while resentment builds)
Better: Can we talk about how the handoffs are going? (opens it, but there's no actual ask)
Best: When changes come in after final approval, the published version can end up inconsistent. Please route changes through the review thread from now on — that keeps us all working from the same version.

DECISION TREE

If The situation is unsafe or threatening

Disengage and use a formal or safety process. Don't use DEAR MAN to stay in danger.

"I'm going to stop this conversation here."

If You don't yet know your objective

Pause and write one sentence before you speak.

"I want X. / I'm not willing to do Y."

If The main need is validation or repair, not a request

Validate, apologise or listen first; hold the ask for now.

"I can see this is frustrating. Can we start there?"

If One clean request would do the job

Use a single direct ask and skip the full sequence.

"Please send the figures by 2 pm."

If Emotion, pushback or negotiation is likely

Use the full DEAR MAN sequence, negotiating only the flexible detail.

"Here's what happened, here's the effect, here's what I need, here's why it helps."

If They keep deflecting after two restatements

Stop repeating and move to your prepared exit line.

"I'm going to pause here and revisit this later."

SCENARIOS

Workplace deadline — repeated late inputs

Run the full sequence, then negotiate one flexible detail while the deadline itself holds. — "The last two inputs arrived under a day before deadline, which leaves me rushing. I need them by noon the day before — if the appendix is late, send the core figures first."

A friend asks for repeated favours

Acknowledge you want to help, name the pattern, then give a clear no with an earlier-notice offer. — "You've asked me to cover transport three times this month. I care about helping, but it's affecting my own schedule. I can't drive this weekend — if you ask earlier next time, I can tell you what's realistic."

A family boundary at dinner

Describe the recurring moment, own the feeling, state the limit, offer a private alternative. — "When the conversation turns to my finances at dinner, I feel exposed. I'm not going to discuss my budget at family meals — I'm happy to talk privately if there's a practical concern."

A written or digital message

Put the facts, impact and ask in one clear message and route future changes cleanly. — "To keep this clear: the file was changed after approval, so the published version may be inconsistent. Please route any further changes through the review thread — that keeps everyone on the same version."

Saying no to extra work when you're at capacity

Acknowledge the urgency, state the limit, offer a smaller concrete alternative. — "I know this is urgent. I'm already committed to two things today, so I can't take the whole task — I can review one section by 4 pm or help find who else has capacity."

High-emotion conflict

Validate the feeling first, then step into a single held request; don't weaponise the structure. — "I can see this is frustrating. I still need to stay with the decision about Saturday — I can't attend, and I can talk about alternatives for next week."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The situation is unsafe and disengaging is wiser.
- The real need is emotional validation before any problem solving.
- You don't yet know what you're actually asking for.
- You'd be using the structure to punish, pressure or corner.
- The person has already said no and you're tempted to repeat harder.
- A formal process, mediator, manager, clinician or legal adviser is required.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Pick the objective

Choose one real request or boundary from your own life. Write the single sentence you most want the other person to understand.

Day 2 — Draft the four DEAR sentences

Write one line each for Describe, Express, Assert and Reinforce. Keep Describe to observable facts only — no motives or

character claims.

Day 3 — Sharpen the Assert

Cut the Assert sentence until you can say it in one breath. Strip any blame, and swap “you have to” for “I need” or “I can’t.”

Day 4 — Mark negotiable vs fixed

Underline what can flex (timing, format, sequence, scope) and what can’t (the core need). Write one negotiate line that offers a flexible detail while holding the core.

Day 5 — Rehearse the tone

Say the whole script aloud once in a warm voice and once in a firm voice. Write two Mindful return lines for when the conversation drifts.

Day 6 — Pressure-test it

Have a partner (or yourself) deflect with “Why are you making this a big deal?” or “You do this too.” Practise one calm return line, then your exit line.

Day 7 — Run it for real

Use the minimum viable move in one live conversation. Afterwards, note the one sentence you’d shorten or drop next time.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I describe observable facts rather than motives or character?
- Was my ask or no specific enough that they could act on it?
- Did I reinforce a constructive reason rather than threaten or bribe?
- Did I stay mindful without ignoring legitimate information?
- Did I negotiate the details without surrendering the core boundary?
- Did I stop or pause when repetition stopped being useful?